

Interviewer Effect Simulation Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 30-40 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	interviewer-effect-simulation

Big idea: In human sciences, the person asking can become part of the evidence produced.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Question: 'How useful is homework for learning?' Styles: warm, rushed, leading, skeptical, neutral. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Question: 'What makes a classroom discussion good?' Styles: encouraging, distracted, formal. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Interviewer Effect Simulation Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Question: 'What makes a classroom discussion good?' Styles: encouraging, distracted, formal. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — In human sciences, the person asking can become part of the evidence produced.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Interviewer Effect Simulation Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	How can data be shaped by the method used to collect it?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Question: 'How useful is homework for learning?' Styles: warm, rushed, leading, skeptical, neutral.
- Question: 'What makes a classroom discussion good?' Styles: encouraging, distracted, formal.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Activity Steps

1. Pairs receive the same interview question but different interviewer style cards.
2. Students conduct short, low-stakes interviews.
3. Respondents reflect on how the style affected their answer.
4. Groups compare differences in length, confidence, and content.
5. Debrief interviewer effects and research reliability.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: How can data be shaped by the method used to collect it?
- Can a neutral interview ever be fully neutral?
- What does ethical interviewing require?

Knowledge Questions

- How can data be shaped by the method used to collect it?
- What makes interview evidence reliable?
- How do ethics and method interact in human sciences?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with students answer the same question to a peer, teacher, stranger, or anonymous form. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...